

DIRECT vs. INDIRECT OBJECTS

Grammar Quick Guide

Direct and indirect objects can be difficult to identify because they can both refer to people, and both can appear with **a**. Instead of looking for one perfect rule, it is more useful to recognize a few common patterns.

1 The Direct Object

The **direct object (DO)** completes the action of many verbs. A useful first strategy is to ask a neutral question with **what + verb?**, without assuming what the answer will be.

¿Qué compras? → Compro **un libro**.
¿Qué comes? → Como **una manzana**.
¿Qué necesitas? → Necesito **ayuda**.
¿Qué ves? → Veo **un coche**.

The answer is the direct object.

A simple pattern is:

SUBJECT → VERB → DIRECT OBJECT

Ana → compra → un libro

The answer doesn't have to be a thing

“What?” is only a strategy for finding what completes the verb. The answer can also be a person or an animal:

¿Qué ves? → Veo **un perro**.
¿Qué ves? → Veo **a María**.

Both **un perro** and **a María** are direct objects.

When the direct object is a specific person, Spanish normally uses the **personal a**:

Veo a María. Ayudo a Carlos.
Invito a Laura. Llamo a mi mamá.

The **a** does not make these indirect objects.

Important: Don't use **a** to decide whether an object is direct or indirect.

2 Don't Force the "What?" Question

The **what + verb?** strategy is useful, but it isn't a perfect grammar rule. With some verbs, the question sounds unnatural:

ayudar a alguien — to help someone
invitar a alguien — to invite someone
llamar a alguien — to call someone
buscar a alguien — to look for someone

Instead of forcing a strange question like "What do you invite?", learn these as common patterns. In each of these patterns, **alguien** is the direct object.

This is an important part of learning objects in Spanish: **patterns are often more useful than one universal question.**

3 The Indirect Object

Some verbs commonly follow a different pattern:

VERB + SOMETHING + TO SOMEONE

For example:

Doy un libro a María.

I give a book to María.

First, identify what is being given:

¿Qué doy? → un libro
un libro = DIRECT OBJECT

Then we have another person:

a María = INDIRECT OBJECT

The complete pattern is:

SUBJECT → VERB → DIRECT OBJECT → INDIRECT OBJECT

Yo → doy → un libro → a María

This same pattern appears with many common verbs:

dar algo a alguien — give something to someone
enviar algo a alguien — send something to someone
mostrar algo a alguien — show something to someone
explicar algo a alguien — explain something to someone
decir algo a alguien — tell something to someone
prestar algo a alguien — lend something to someone

Examples:**Doy [un libro] [a Ana].**

DO: un libro · IO: a Ana

Muestro [la foto] [a Carlos].

DO: la foto · IO: a Carlos

Explico [el problema] [a María].

DO: el problema · IO: a María

*** Sometimes “something” isn't said**

Some patterns can appear without the direct object:

Pregunto la hora al profesor.

DO: la hora · IO: al profesor

Pregunto al profesor.

IO: al profesor

The complete pattern is **preguntar (algo) a alguien**, but Spanish doesn't always need to say the **algo**.The same can happen with patterns such as **escribir (algo) a alguien** and **responder (algo) a alguien**.**An indirect object does not need a direct object to be explicitly present in the sentence.****4 Compare the Patterns**

The same person can be a direct object in one sentence and an indirect object in another.

Sentence	Pattern	Direct Object	Indirect Object
Veo a Ana.	ver + someone	a Ana	—
Muestro la foto a Ana.	mostrar + something + to someone	la foto	a Ana
Invito a Carlos.	invitar + someone	a Carlos	—
Envío una invitación a Carlos.	enviar + something + to someone	una invitación	a Carlos

Notice that **a Ana** and **a Carlos** appear in both columns. The word **a** alone cannot tell you whether something is a direct or indirect object.The **pattern of the verb** is more important.

5 Common Patterns to Recognize

VERB + SOMEONE → Direct Object

ver a alguien — see someone

ayudar a alguien — help someone

llamar a alguien — call someone

invitar a alguien — invite someone

buscar a alguien — look for someone

Veo a Pedro. → Pedro = DO

Ayudo a mi hermana. → mi hermana = DO

Invito a mis amigos. → mis amigos = DO

VERB + SOMETHING + TO SOMEONE → Direct + Indirect Object

dar algo a alguien — give something to someone

mostrar algo a alguien — show something to someone

enviar algo a alguien — send something to someone

explicar algo a alguien — explain something to someone

decir algo a alguien — tell something to someone

prestar algo a alguien — lend something to someone

Doy el libro a Pedro.

DO: el libro · IO: a Pedro

Explico la situación a mi hermana.

DO: la situación · IO: a mi hermana

Muestro las fotos a mis amigos.

DO: las fotos · IO: a mis amigos

How to Identify Them

When you see a new sentence:

- 1. Start with the verb.** What pattern is it following?
- 2. Look for the direct object first.** Try **what + verb?** as a neutral question when it sounds natural. Remember that the answer can be a person or a thing, and sometimes the direct object may be **implicit rather than explicitly stated**.
- 3. Don't automatically classify a person with "a" as indirect.** Veo a Ana and ayudo a Ana contain direct objects.
- 4. Look for a second object.** With patterns such as **dar algo a alguien** or **mostrar algo a alguien**, **algo** is the direct object and **alguien** is the indirect object.
- 5. Learn common verb patterns.** There is no single question that works perfectly with every Spanish verb. Recognizing patterns will make identifying objects much easier over time.

Quick Reference

Direct Object Patterns	Direct + Indirect Object Patterns
comprar algo	dar algo a alguien
necesitar algo/alguien	enviar algo a alguien
ver algo/a alguien	mostrar algo a alguien
ayudar a alguien	explicar algo a alguien
llamar a alguien	decir algo a alguien
invitar a alguien	prestar algo a alguien
buscar algo/a alguien	enseñar algo a alguien

Remember

Person ≠ indirect object.

A + person ≠ indirect object.

Focus on the **verb and its pattern**:

ver a alguien → DIRECT

mostrar algo a alguien → DIRECT + INDIRECT